

The singing staircase

Lesson 1 • listen, sing and feel the pulse

Teacher's guide. © 2026 Music Motion.

For: ages 8 to 12, the whole class. **Length:** 50 minutes.

What they learn: to hear pitch, to sing a note and to feel the pulse.

What you need: a computer with speakers and, if available, a projector. **No music knowledge needed:** the keyboard and the tuner do the work; you guide.

Before the lesson (5 minutes, at home): open [the Cosmic Keyboard](#), press **Z X C V B** **N M** and listen to the scale from C to B. Open [the tuner](#) and sing a note to see how it shows it.

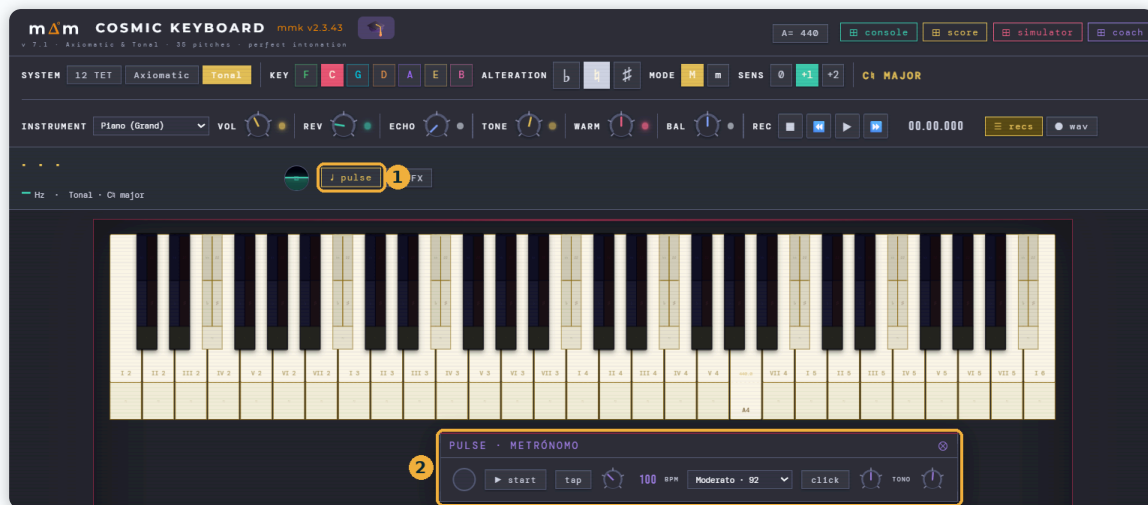
Before you start: the pulse

What is the pulse?

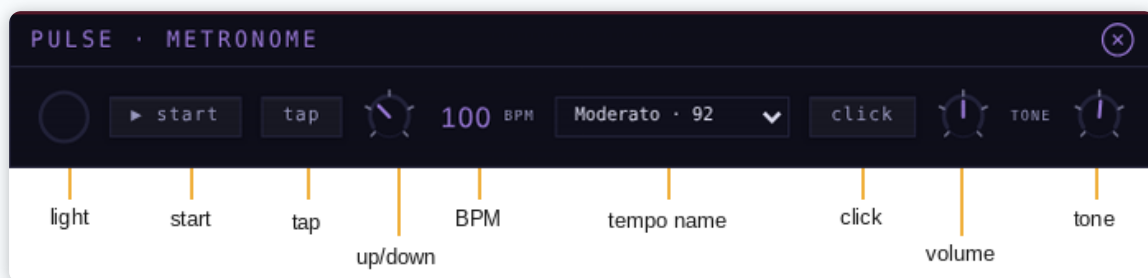
The pulse is the steady heartbeat of music: always the same distance apart, like the tick-tock of a clock or footsteps when walking. When we clap along to a song, we are clapping the pulse. Everyone who plays or sings together follows the same pulse.

The **metronome** is the machine that marks that beat with a light and a sound, so the class stays together. Its speed is measured in **BPM**, beats per minute: **60 BPM = one beat per second**. More BPM, faster.

Where to find it in the Cosmic Keyboard



1. **Open the metronome:** press the **pulse** button (1), the one with a little musical note, in the third row from the top, next to **FX**.
2. The **PULSE • METRONOME** panel (2) appears below the keyboard.



3. **Choose the tempo** (the speed of the pulse). The easiest way: press **tap** several times in a row, at the speed you want; the metronome measures it and shows the **BPM**. You can also turn the **knob** next to tap: it raises or lowers the BPM, and the list shows the musical name of that tempo (for example *Andante* • 76 or *Moderato* • 92). Or pick a tempo straight from the list. To begin, go slow: about **60 BPM**.
4. **Start it with start.** The **light** (the circle) flashes on every beat.
5. **To hear it,** switch on **click**. The two knobs on the right adjust the click: the first one, its **volume**; the **TONE** knob, whether it sounds higher or lower.
6. **To close it,** press (X), at the top right of the panel.

The lesson, step by step

1 Listen

10 min

On the right of the Keyboard is the **RECORDINGS** list (if you can't see it, press **≡ recs**). Press ► on Bach's "Sinfonia No. 1". Ask:

"Does the music go up or down? When does it sound like it's coming home?"

There are no wrong answers: the point is to listen carefully.

2 The staircase

10 min

Play **Z X C V B N M** slowly, one key at a time. The class sings each note on “la”. Then from the top down.

3 The echo

10 min

You play one key of the staircase; the class sings it. Then two keys in a row, then three. A pupil comes up to play and the class answers.

4 The tuner

10 min

A pupil sings a long note in front of the computer, with [the tuner](#) open. Everyone sees the name of the note being sung. Repeat with others.

“Who can sing exactly the same note as the keyboard?”

5 The pulse

10 min

Open the metronome (**pulse**), set a slow tempo with **tap**, press **start** and switch on **click** (see “Before you start: the pulse”). The class claps the pulse while you play the staircase, one key per beat. To finish, a volunteer plays the staircase alone, following the pulse.

The keys and their notes

Z C	X D	C E	V F	B G	N A	M B
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The bottom row of the computer keyboard is the staircase: from Z (C) to M (B). One octave higher, the same staircase starts on A, and another one higher on Q.

How to tell it worked: most of the class sings back a note that was played, and the class keeps the pulse with their claps through the whole staircase.

These lessons are a starting point. Each teacher can design the examples to suit their own class. For our part, we will keep adding lesson topics according to the requests we receive through the [contact form](#).

✂ cut out and take home

Let's play with music at home

For parents · 10 minutes a week · no music knowledge needed

Today in class we learned to sing the notes of the keyboard. This week, play together:



Each key on the bottom row is a note: Z is C, X is D... up to M, which is B.

1. Open the keyboard on the computer: musicmotionsuite.com/apps/mmk-demo.html
2. **The echo:** one person plays a key between **Z** and **M**; the other sings it. Then swap.
3. **The tuner:** your child sings a long note in front of tuner.mariomaurano.com and looks at its name. Can they sing the same note as the keyboard?

The microphone only works on your computer: nothing is recorded or sent. No sign-up needed.